SKILL.md · frontmatter

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name: non-ai-looking-images
description: Write and refine image-generation prompts so results look like real
photographs or real hand-made art instead of glossy, generic AI output. Use this skill
whenever the user asks for an image, photo, illustration, thumbnail, product shot,
portrait or social media visual, asks to make an image "look real", "less AI", "less
plastic" or "more natural", or shares a generated image that looks fake and wants it
fixed, even if they never say "realistic".
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Non-AI-Looking Images

Plan every image the way a photographer or illustrator would plan a shot. Most fake-looking results come from three causes: vague prompts, conflicting directions, and old prompt habits such as "8K, masterpiece, best quality". This skill replaces those with concrete visual detail.

When to use

- The user asks for any photographic or illustrated image.
- The user says an image looks AI-generated, plastic, airbrushed, too perfect or too glossy.
- The user wants a consistent visual style for a brand, website or social posts.
- The user shares a generated image and wants it edited to look more natural.

Workflow

1. **Pick the mode.** Decide whether the user needs a photograph (go to Rules and Prompt formula) or a hand-made style (go to Style templates). If the user wants brand visuals and hasn't asked for photorealism, offer a style template first.
2. **Fill the prompt formula.** Use only the slots that serve the scene.
3. **Run the rules check.** Remove quality filler, resolve conflicts, move the subject off-center.
4. **Generate.**
5. **Inspect.** Check hands, shadows, reflections, text, proportions and skin. Find the single most noticeable problem.
6. **Fix one issue at a time** using the Troubleshooting table. Keep everything that already works.
7. **Finish** with post-processing if the tools allow it.

Rules

- **Never use quality tags.** Do not write "realistic", "realism", "hyper-real", "photorealistic", "8K", "4K", "masterpiece" or "best quality". Real photos in training data are captioned as photos. These tags pull toward rendered, painted or edited images. Write "a photograph", "an amateur photo" or "a snapshot" instead.
- **Use concrete visual detail.** Name the light source and direction, the materials, the camera, the angle and the framing. Adjectives give the model nothing to work with.
- **Describe what to show, not what to avoid.** "Relaxed hands resting on the table" beats a list of hand defects.
- **Keep directions compatible.** Never combine natural skin texture with flawless beauty retouching.

- **Do not center the subject staring at the camera.** This is the default AI composition. Use candid moments, a subject looking away or off-frame, and rule-of-thirds placement.
- **Do not blur every background.** Portraits may use a soft background. Interiors and landscapes need more in focus.
- **Keep imperfections restrained.** Too many pores, wrinkles or blemishes look fake in a new way.
- **More words are not better.** Cut details that don't serve the scene.
- **State the format** when the destination is known, for example 1080x1080, 1:1 for an Instagram post.

Prompt formula

```
Subject + Setting + Lighting + Framing + Material Details + Camera Feel + Key Constraints
```

This is a checklist, not a fixed order.

Slot	What to write	Example phrasing
Subject	Who or what, doing what, specific age or type	a man in his 30s reading a paperback
Setting	A specific, believable place	a corner table in a small cafe by the window
Lighting	Source, direction, quality, time of day	soft morning daylight from the left
Framing	Shot size, angle, eye level, placement	waist-up, three-quarter view, eye level, off-center
Materials	How each surface looks and takes light	visible linen weave, matte wood, glazed ceramic
Camera feel	Camera, lens, film or phone look	35mm lens look, Fujifilm-style color, light grain
Constraints	What stays true or simple	straight vertical lines, natural proportions

Reference: lighting

- Use one clear light source so highlights and shadows agree.
- Say how light lands on objects: "a soft shadow beneath the mug" places the object in the scene.
- Safe defaults: window light, overcast daylight, morning light, a single large softbox.
- If the user has a real photo with light they like, use it as a reference image for lighting and color.

Reference: materials and texture

- Give each main material its own finish: matte fabric, glazed ceramic, brushed metal, rough wood.
- For people, ask for subtle skin texture and natural tonal variation.
- Add small lived-in details that fit the subject: a creased shirt, a loose strand of hair, a crumpled napkin.
- A clean product shot needs only light surface texture.

Reference: camera language

- Name a camera or look: "DSLR, Canon EOS 5D look", "Fujifilm-inspired", "casual iPhone snapshot", "35mm film".
- Pair it with visible qualities: gentle colors, light grain, shallow depth of field, eye-level view.
- Camera metadata works. Copy the settings from a real photo you want to match: brand, model, lens, focal length, ISO, aperture.

- For a phone look, ask for slightly softer detail, natural dynamic range, mild sensor noise, imperfect exposure, handheld, candid.

Troubleshooting

Problem	Change in the prompt
Skin looks plastic or airbrushed	Subtle skin texture, natural tonal variation; remove beauty or flawless wording
Object seems to float	Describe the surface under it and a soft contact shadow
Hands look awkward	Simpler pose, such as hands resting on a table
Furniture or buildings stretched	Eye-level viewpoint, straight vertical lines, consistent proportions
Everything is glossy	Give each material its own finish
Image feels too perfect	Handheld, candid, light grain, mild softness; move subject off-center
Background always blurred	Ask for more of the scene in focus and describe background details
Generic AI composition	Subject looking away, off-center, then crop differently after generating

Style templates

Use these when a consistent hand-made style fits better than a photo. Replace `[OBJECTS]` with exactly what should appear. Keep one small accent color.

Pen-and-ink sketch

```
Rough pen-and-ink sketch on slightly off-white paper. Wobbly black lines with small ink skips, as if drawn fast in a notebook. Faint paper grain and a light shadow along one edge like a scan. Show only: [OBJECTS]. No background marks, shading or gradients. Optional: one tiny highlight in bright orange.
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Paper collage

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Hand-made paper collage. Torn-edge cut-outs on kraft paper with light drop shadows so the layers feel physical. A few tape or glue marks. Show only: [OBJECTS]. No digital gradients or fancy textures; rely on rough edges and overlap. One piece of tape or one arrow may be bright orange.
```

35mm film snapshot

```
35mm film photo. Mild grain, warm color shift, a soft red light leak on one side, edges slightly soft like a quick handheld shot. Show only: [OBJECTS]. No heavy filters or overlays.
```

Watercolor wash

```
Loose watercolor on cold-press paper. Pigment pools at the edges and bleeds together. Minimal, shaky pencil-like outlines. Show only: [OBJECTS]. No hard shadows or added gradients. One area may use a bright orange wash.
```

Examples

Portrait

```
A candid waist-up photo of a woman in her 20s reading beside a cafe window, Fujifilm-style color, light grain. She glances at someone outside the frame with a small smile. Soft daylight from the left shows natural skin texture and a few loose strands of hair. Blue linen shirt with gentle folds, forearms resting on the table, eye-level framing, background softly out of focus.
```

Product

```
DSLR studio photo of a white ceramic mug on a warm gray matte surface, 50mm lens look. Three-quarter view at mug height with the handle fully visible. A large softbox above and to the right makes one broad reflection on the glaze and a soft contact shadow under the base. Subtle ceramic texture, sharp focus across the mug, neutral colors, plain background.
```

Interior

```
A casual phone photo of a small reading corner, taken from the doorway at eye level. A linen armchair next to an oak bookshelf, wool rug under the chair's front legs. Afternoon daylight from the right, soft shadows falling left. Visible fabric weave, wood grain, a lightly creased cushion. Straight vertical lines, natural proportions, chair and shelf both in focus, warm muted colors.
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Social media

```
Square 1080x1080 editorial photo for Instagram of a man in his mid-30s working on a laptop at a sunlit cafe table. Natural morning light, soft diffused shadows, three-quarter angle, Canon EOS 5D look. Natural skin texture, subtle background blur, sharp focus on the face. No distortion, artificial colors or stylized filters.
```

Editing a reference image

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Keep the subject from the reference image: same face, expression, pose, clothing and composition. Replace the polished beauty look with a believable phone photo: slight facial asymmetry, visible pores, faint redness, natural under-eye texture, a few messy strands of hair. Softer phone-level detail, natural dynamic range, mild lens softness.
```

Reference images

- Use one when the result must match an existing person, product shape, composition or style.
- State what to preserve (shape, proportions, color, angle) and what to change (light, background, texture).
- Compare output to the reference closely. Handles, rims and logos often drift.

Post-processing

Apply when the tools allow it.

- **Low-denoise pass.** Run the image through a realism-focused model at very low denoise (about 0.03 to 0.25). This adds skin texture and grain while keeping the composition. Check hands afterward.
- **Texture upscale.** Downscale 2x (Lanczos), then upscale 4x with a generative upscaler. The result is 2x the original size with more natural fine detail.
- **Manual edits.** Lower contrast slightly, adjust color balance, add light film grain, sharpen gently with hair masked out.

- **Model choice.** Fine-tuned realism models and amateur-photo LoRAs beat base models. Fast few-step LoRAs can cause a plastic look.
- **Last resort.** Train a small style model on ordinary, imperfect photos such as old phone or social media uploads.

Final checklist

- [ ] No quality tags; the prompt asks for a photograph or a named hand-made medium
- [ ] One light source with direction stated
- [ ] Each main material has its own finish
- [ ] Camera or lens look named, paired with visible qualities
- [ ] Subject off-center or candid, not staring into the lens
- [ ] Imperfections present but restrained
- [ ] No conflicting directions
- [ ] Format and aspect ratio match the destination
- [ ] After generating: hands, shadows, reflections, text and proportions checked

Sources

Mick Rudskyi, "Here's how to make your AI images look good and match your style" (LinkedIn); Kling AI, "How to Make AI Pictures Look Real"; threads on r/PromptEngineering and r/StableDiffusion.